ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Irrealis without if

Express unreal conditions through inversion, implied protases, but for, otherwise and counterfactual comparison. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use irrealis without if to build counterfactual meaning when the condition is distributed across the discourse rather than introduced by if while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Express unreal conditions through inversion, implied protases, but for, otherwise and counterfactual comparison.

MODEL

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

but for/otherwise/as if/inversion + counterfactual result

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main irrealis without if patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses build counterfactual meaning when the condition is distributed across the discourse rather than introduced by if.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in formal prose, argument, narrative and concise commentary.

Build meaning before form

Express unreal conditions through inversion, implied protases, but for, otherwise and counterfactual comparison.

What irrealis without if communicates

Express unreal conditions through inversion, implied protases, but for, otherwise and counterfactual comparison.

The central purpose is to build counterfactual meaning when the condition is distributed across the discourse rather than introduced by if. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.	the factor that prevented an unreal result
The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.	an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause
He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.	a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: but for/otherwise/as if/inversion + counterfactual result. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
But-for condition	but for + noun, modal result	But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.
Otherwise condition	statement; otherwise + modal result	The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.
Counterfactual comparison	as if/as though + remote form	He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
the factor that prevented an unreal result	But-for condition
an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause	Otherwise condition
a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful	Counterfactual comparison

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in formal prose, argument, narrative and concise commentary. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02
but for/otherwise/as if/inversion	counterfactual result

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: build counterfactual meaning when the condition is distributed across the discourse rather than introduced by if.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits formal prose, argument, narrative and concise commentary.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
But-for condition	but for + noun, modal result	But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.
Otherwise condition	statement; otherwise + modal result	The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.
Counterfactual comparison	as if/as though + remote form	He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.	the factor that prevented an unreal result
The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.	an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause
He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.	a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not follow but for directly with a finite clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Ensure the antecedent of otherwise is explicit enough to reconstruct.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Use tense to signal remoteness; do not assume as if always marks unreality.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the factor that prevented an unreal result?

OPTIONS But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed. · The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated. · He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause?

OPTIONS The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated. · He described the proposal as though it had already been approved. · But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful?

OPTIONS He described the proposal as though it had already been approved. · But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed. · The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the factor that prevented an unreal result · an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause · a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause · a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful · the factor that prevented an unreal result

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful · the factor that prevented an unreal result · an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: But-for condition / Otherwise condition / Counterfactual comparison · Gap 2: the factor that prevented an unreal result / an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause / a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Otherwise condition / Counterfactual comparison / But-for condition · Gap 2: an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause / a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful / the factor that prevented an unreal result

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"He described the proposal as though it had already been approved." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Counterfactual comparison / But-for condition / Otherwise condition · Gap 2: a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful / the factor that prevented an unreal result / an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses the factor that prevented an unreal result: _____. Choose the model that expresses an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause: _____. Choose the model that expresses a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful: _____. Choose the model built with but for + noun, modal result: _____. Choose the model built with statement; otherwise + modal result: _____. Choose the model built with as if/as though + remote form: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed. · He described the proposal as though it had already been approved. · The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____, the defect would have gone unnoticed. The alarm was reset; _____, the building would have been evacuated. He described the proposal _____. State the full structural pattern for But-for condition: _____. State the full structural pattern for Otherwise condition: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “If there had been no final inspection, the defect would have been missed.” using the But-for condition pattern to express the factor that prevented an unreal result.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “If the alarm had not been reset, evacuation would have followed.” using the Otherwise condition pattern to express an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “He spoke in a way that falsely implied prior approval.” using the Counterfactual comparison pattern to express a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “If there had been no final inspection, the defect would have been missed.” using the But-for condition pattern to express the factor that prevented an unreal result.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use But-for condition to express the factor that prevented an unreal result, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Otherwise condition to express an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Counterfactual comparison to express a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

But-for condition is the best match because the factor that prevented an unreal result.

A2

The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

Otherwise condition is the best match because an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause.

A3

He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

Counterfactual comparison is the best match because a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful.

A4

the factor that prevented an unreal result

The But-for condition pattern communicates the factor that prevented an unreal result.

A5

an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause

The Otherwise condition pattern communicates an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause.

A6

a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

The Counterfactual comparison pattern communicates a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

But-for condition / the factor that prevented an unreal result

The structure belongs to the But-for condition pattern. Its communicative purpose is the factor that prevented an unreal result.

B2

Otherwise condition / an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause

The structure belongs to the Otherwise condition pattern. Its communicative purpose is an implied negative condition recovered from the previous clause.

B3

Counterfactual comparison / a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful

The structure belongs to the Counterfactual comparison pattern. Its communicative purpose is a comparison presented as contrary to fact or doubtful.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

But-for condition: but for + noun, modal result.

C2

The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

Otherwise condition: statement; otherwise + modal result.

C3

He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

Counterfactual comparison: as if/as though + remote form.

C4

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

But-for condition: but for + noun, modal result.

C5

The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

Otherwise condition: statement; otherwise + modal result.

C6

He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

Counterfactual comparison: as if/as though + remote form.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

But for the final inspection

But-for condition requires “But for the final inspection” in this model. but for + noun, modal result.

D2

otherwise

Otherwise condition requires “otherwise” in this model. statement; otherwise + modal result.

D3

as though it had already been approved

Counterfactual comparison requires “as though it had already been approved” in this model. as if/as though + remote form.

D4

but for + noun, modal result

But-for condition is built as but for + noun, modal result.

D5

statement; otherwise + modal result

Otherwise condition is built as statement; otherwise + modal result.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

but for + noun, modal result. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended but-for condition effect.

E2

The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated.

statement; otherwise + modal result. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended otherwise condition effect.

E3

He described the proposal as though it had already been approved.

as if/as though + remote form. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended counterfactual comparison effect.

E4

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed.

but for + noun, modal result. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended but-for condition effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

But for the final inspection, the defect would have gone unnoticed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses but for + noun, modal result accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The alarm was reset; otherwise, the building would have been evacuated. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses statement; otherwise + modal result accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

He described the proposal as though it had already been approved. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses as if/as though + remote form accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____